UNIT 8

Harsha and Rise of Regional Kingdoms

Learning Objectives

I Harsha

- To know the ancestors and contemporaries of Harsha
- To learn about the military conquests of Harsha
- To understand the nature of Harsha's administration
- To obtain knowledge of the religious policy of Harsha
- To become aware of the socio-cultural life of the people in India from the accounts of Hieun Tsang

II The Palas

- To know the history of Palas as a strong regional power in eastern India
- To learn the contribution of prominent Pala rulers such as Dharmapala, Devapala and Mahipala I in administering their kingdom
- To understand the significance of their role in the spread of Mahayana Buddhism in the Ganges plain
- To gain knowledge about the contribution of Palas to literature, art and architecture

III The Rashtrakutas

- To know the greatness of the Rashtrakutas
- To learn the fact that successful rulers, Krishna I through Krishna III, prevented the Pallava expansion northward.
- To apprise yourself of the development of Kannada literature under the patronage of Rashtrakutas.

I Harsha

Introduction

North India splintered into several warrior kingdoms after the downfall of the Gupta Empire. Excepting in the areas that were subdued by the Huns (modern Punjab, Rajasthan and Malwa), regional identity became pronounced with the emergence of many small states. Maithrakas had organised a powerful state in Sourashtra (Gujarat), with Valabhi as their capital. Agra and Awadh were organised into an independent and sovereign state by the Maukharis. The Vakatakas had recovered their position of ascendency in the western Deccan. Despite political rivalry and conflict among these states, Thaneswar, lying north of Delhi between Sutlej and Yamuna, was formed into an independent state by Pushyabhutis. It rose to prominence under Harsha. Harsha ruled the kingdom as large as that of the Guptas from 606 to 647 CE.

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